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Tracking the Metrics that Matter: Active Engagement Time vs. Time Spent on Page

In the digital publishing world, accurately measuring user engagement is crucial to understanding the effectiveness of content and optimizing user experience. Two key metrics often used by publishers are Active Engagement Time (AET) and Time Spent on Page (TSOP). While these metrics are closely related, they focus on different aspects of user interaction, offering complementary insights into how users engage with online content.



Content Highlight:

- What is Active Engagement Time (AET)?
- How to Calculate Active Engagement Time (AET)?
- What is the importance of Tracking Active Engagement Time (AET)?
- Understanding Time Spent on Page (TSOP)
- Calculating Time Spent on Page (TSOP)
- The importance of Tracking Time Spent on Page (TSOP)
- Monitoring Both Metrics with Advanced Dashboards & Alerts
- Conclusion

Active Engagement Time (AET): Measuring Active User Interaction

Active Engagement Time (AET) is a qualitative metric that measures the duration during which a user is actively interacting with content on a webpage. Unlike simple page view metrics, AET focuses on active engagement, such as scrolling, clicking, typing, watching videos, and other forms of interaction.

This metric is crucial for understanding how deeply users are engaging with content beyond just having a page open.

How to Calculate Active Engagement Time (AET)

Calculating Active Engagement Time requires tracking specific user interactions and excluding periods of inactivity. Here's a step-by-step process:

1. **Track User Interactions:** Monitor user activities such as scrolling, clicking, typing, mouse movements, or video plays. These events indicate active engagement with the content.
2. **Record Timestamps:** For each interaction, record the exact timestamp to measure the duration between engagement events.
3. **Identify Inactivity Periods:** Determine a predefined threshold (e.g., 30 seconds) for inactivity. If the time between two consecutive interactions exceeds this threshold, consider it a period of inactivity and exclude it from the AET calculation.
4. **Sum Active Intervals:** Calculate the intervals between consecutive engagement events, excluding inactivity periods, to get the total AET for a session. Here's the formula

$$\text{Active Engagement} = \sum \left(\begin{array}{c} \text{Time between} \\ \text{engagement events} \end{array} \right) - \text{Inactivity periods}$$

For example, if a user interactions are recorded at the following times: 0:00 (scroll), 0:10 (click), 0:25 (mouse move), 1:10 (scroll), and 1:20 (click). An inactivity period occurs from 0:55 to 1:05. Then the active intervals are 0:00 to 0:55 (55 seconds) and 1:05 to 1:20 (15 seconds).

Therefore, the total AET = 70 seconds.

The Importance of Tracking Active Engagement Time (AET)

Tracking Active Engagement Time offers several key benefits including:

- **Audience Attention:** Active Engagement Time provides insights into how long users are actively consuming content, helping publishers understand which content holds their audience's attention.
- **Content Performance:** By comparing Active Engagement Time across different content types or topics, publishers can gauge the effectiveness of their content and identify areas for improvement.
- **Monetization Strategies:** A high Active Engagement Time indicates that users are more likely to engage with ads, making the website more attractive to advertisers.
- **Improved UX:** Analyzing Active Engagement Time can help identify where users disengage, guiding optimizations in content structure, website features, and navigation for a smoother user experience.

Time Spent on Page (TSOP): Measuring Total Time on Content

Time Spent on a Page (TSOP) is a quantitative metric that measures the total duration a user spends on a specific page. Unlike Active Engagement Time, TSOP does not differentiate between active and passive engagement; it simply records the time between a user arriving on a page and leaving it.

While this metric is less precise in capturing user interaction, it provides valuable insights into overall content engagement.

How to Calculate Time Spent on Page (TSOP)

Time Spent On Page is calculated by tracking page load and unload events:

1. Track Page Load and Unload Events: Record the timestamp when the page loads (onload event) and when the user leaves the page (beforeunload or onunload event).
2. Calculate Time Difference: Subtract the timestamp of the page load event from the timestamp of the page unload event to determine the total time spent on the page.

Time Spent on Page Formula

$$\text{Time Spent on Page} = \text{Timestamp of Page Unload} - \text{Timestamp of Page Load}$$

For example, if a user loads a page at 10:00:00 and leaves at 10:05:30, the Time Spent on Page is calculated as follows:

Time Spent on Page = 10:05:30 - 10:00:00

TSOP = 5 minutes and 30 seconds

The Importance of Tracking Time Spent on Page (TSOP)

Time Spent On Page complements Active Engagement Time by providing a broader view of user engagement:

- Engagement: Time Spent On Page helps assess whether users are genuinely engaged with content, as opposed to quickly bouncing off the page.
- Content Depth: Longer Time Spent On Page on complex articles suggests that users are taking

- Campaign Effectiveness: Time Spent On Page can help identify which marketing channels bring in users who spend more time on content, enabling publishers to optimize future campaigns.
- A/B Testing: Time Spent On Page is useful in A/B testing different content elements, such as headlines or layouts, to determine which variations keep users on the page longer.

To learn more about this and more advanced metrics that publishers should look out for and how to optimize them effectively, download our free eBook by clicking the image below:



Monitoring Both Metrics with Advanced Dashboards and Alerts

To ensure good performance, it is essential to continuously monitor Active Engagement Time and Time Spent On Page using advanced web analytics tools like [Google Analytics](#), [Adobe Analytics](#), and Assertive Yield's [Yield Intelligence](#).

Regularly reviewing analytics data with holistic Dashboards and Alert Templates allows publishers to identify patterns and trends, make data-driven decisions, and implement iterative improvements to content and engagement strategies, such as:

Engagement Time & Time Spent on Page Overview Dashboard

Use comprehensive dashboards to track Active Engagement Time and Time Spent On Page metrics across different content sections. This allows for a high-level view of how users interact with content over time.

Active Session in Minutes

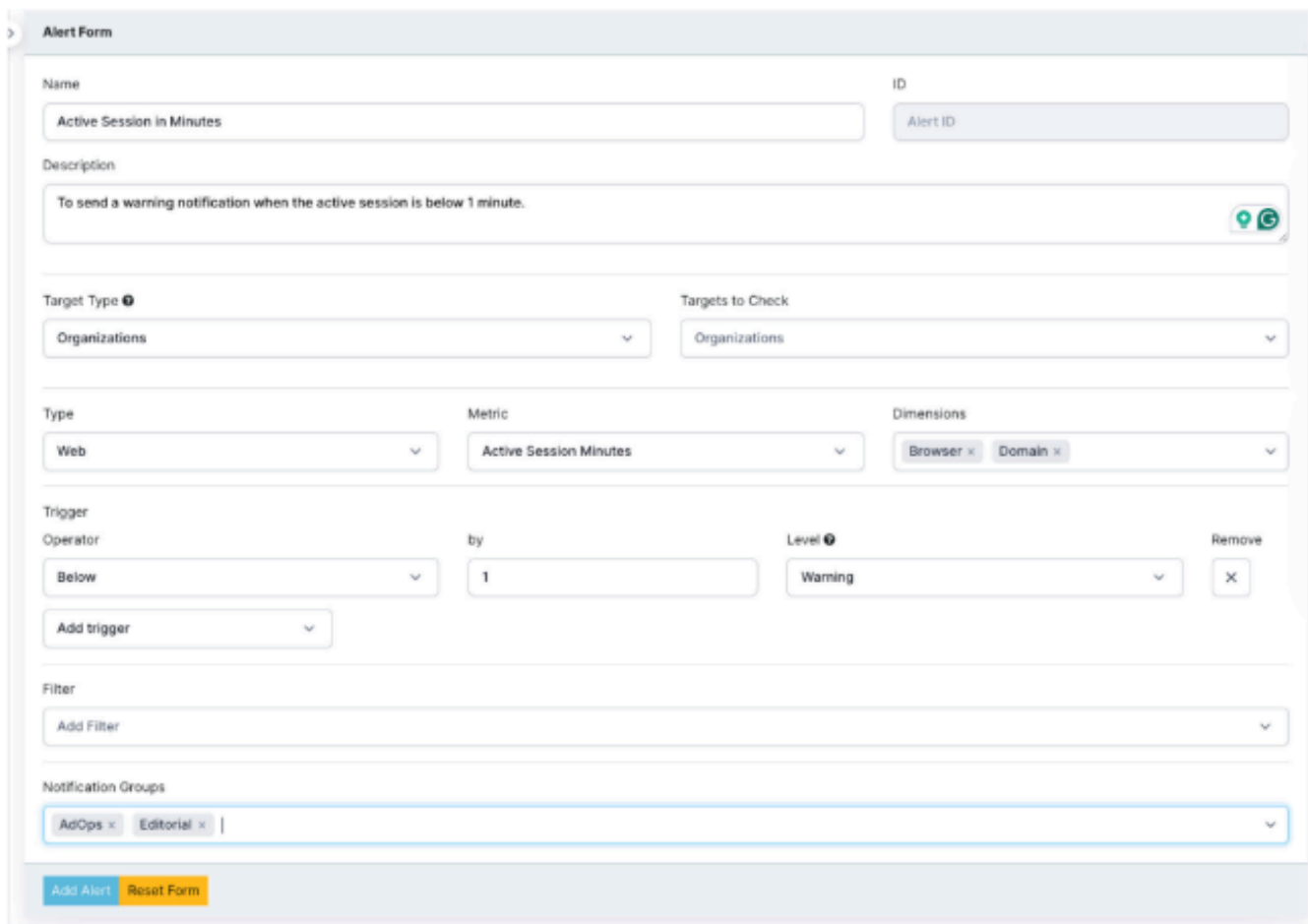
Monitor real-time data on how long users actively engage with sessions across your site. This can highlight periods of peak activity and inform content strategy adjustments.

Track how long users spend on individual pages in real-time. This metric can reveal which pages hold user interest and which may need optimization.

Real-Time Alerts

Set up real-time alerts for significant changes in Active Engagement Time or Time Spent On Page. For example, if AET drops below a certain threshold, an alert can prompt immediate investigation and response to potential issues affecting user engagement.

With [Assertive Yield](#), you can set alerts on Active Session in Minutes, Active PageView in Minutes, and more for easy monitoring and swift troubleshooting.



The screenshot shows the 'Alert Form' interface. It includes fields for 'Name' (Active Session in Minutes) and 'ID' (Alert ID). The 'Description' field contains the text: 'To send a warning notification when the active session is below 1 minute.' Below this, there are dropdown menus for 'Target Type' (Organizations) and 'Targets to Check' (Organizations). The 'Type' is set to 'Web', the 'Metric' is 'Active Session Minutes', and the 'Dimensions' are 'Browser' and 'Domain'. The 'Trigger' section shows 'Operator' set to 'Below', 'by' set to '1', and 'Level' set to 'Warning'. There is an 'Add trigger' button and a 'Remove' button. The 'Filter' section has an 'Add Filter' button. The 'Notification Groups' section shows 'AdOps' and 'Editorial' as selected groups. At the bottom, there are 'Add Alert' and 'Reset Form' buttons.

**Source: Assertive Yield's Demo Data - AY Campaign Overview alert templates available in Yield Intelligence and Yield Manager solutions*

Conclusion

Understanding and effectively utilizing Active Engagement Time and Time Spent On Page can significantly enhance a publisher's ability to engage their audience, optimize content strategy, and improve user satisfaction.

A well-rounded approach to measuring content effectiveness involves balancing both Active Engagement Time and Time Spent On Page. While TSOP provides a broad measure of time spent, AET offers deeper insights into active engagement.

Together, these metrics help publishers better understand user behavior, make informed decisions that drive success, and create content that attracts visitors and keeps them actively engaged.

Are you looking to elevate your digital publishing game, don't miss out on our eBook, "Boosting Performance Metrics for Digital Publishers," where we dive into more metrics, analytics, and strategies that can transform your content approach and maximize reader engagement



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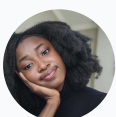
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Check out the associated AY solution

Yield Intelligence

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Angela is a wordsmith who skillfully transforms complex concepts into engaging content, making significant contributions to the advertising industry. Leveraging her wealth of expertise as a content writer, she crafts compelling narratives that seamlessly bridge technology and communication, whether with her pen or keyboard.

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